



Tough times: Indian wrestler Vinesh Phogat made a shock quarterfinal exit at the Tokyo 2020 Olympics. She was subsequently suspended on grounds of indiscipline following her return from Tokyo. AFP

evident at the National championships.

Vinesh was relieved after securing the 55kg crown, even though the field was a weaker one. *“Operation ke baad aayi hoon toh thoda fear tha* (Since I was returning after my operation, I was a little apprehensive). It was like a test for me. I am feeling good. I think I am on the right track. This is an Olympic year. Hopefully, I will stay fit and healthy and give my best for my country.

“Sometimes, even when you are 100 per cent fit, you may not be able to give your best. I gave my 50 per cent and won here. *Wrestling life ko phir se jee rahe hai* (I have started living a wrestler's life once again),” said Vinesh, wearing a smile that had

been missing from her face for the last year.

Vinesh won one bout on technical superiority and two by pinning her rivals. In only one bout, against Tamanna of Haryana, she wrestled cautiously to record a 3-0 win.

“When you go to a competition after recovering from an injury, doubts come to mind. In training, you don't have such doubts. During the rehab phase, for five to six months, I didn't miss a single session. So, I had eliminated that doubt — the fear — from my mind during training. I came here to test myself. In the women's section, there

is good competition. I ended with a win at the start of the year, which is a positive sign.

“I will do wrestling training now because, after the surgery, I had limited time to train. I am happy with my performance, considering where I was before. I have not done strength training and conditioning at a high level. I was playing safe here because I did not want to take any risk in the Olympic year. This win was important.”

Vinesh, who last competed in the September 2022 World Championships and skipped the Asian Games last year due to fitness

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